

Photo Card Organizer

Bring your photos and videos into order. Learn how to import camera cards and folders, arrange your libraries, keep backups, and prepare files for editing.

USER GUIDE | VERSION 0.12.0.dev1

WINDOWS + LINUX

COPY IS THE DEFAULT

MOVE REQUIRES VERIFICATION

About this preview: 0.12.0.dev1

Not a confirmed fix for the 0.11.2 crashes. Use disposable media only.

This guide describes the 0.12.0.dev1 interface preview, which has not been packaged or installed. The earlier dev2 build passed startup and Defender checks, but Sandbox blocked its isolated installation tests. Linux and physical USB-drive testing remain outstanding. The installed app may still show the older layout. See docs/VALIDATION-0.11.3.dev2.md for the earlier build's recorded results.

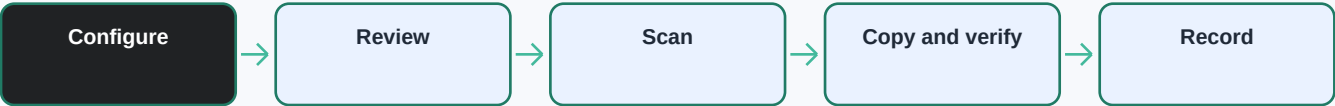
Use the sidebar for Libraries, Sources, Transfers, Settings and Help. Libraries > Check files provides optional checksum checks. Card and folder imports default to Copy. Move library defaults to Move; select Copy and keep originals to leave a separate library behind.

Help & about contains detailed logging and report export. Full-memory capture requires separate consent in the launcher and a Microsoft CDB debugger. Dumps stay local, can be large, and may contain private data. Do not upload them automatically.

The separate 0.11.3.dev1 diagnostic ZIP is still available for crash investigation. If you are using that older package, extract it and start PhotoCardOrganizer-Diagnostic.bat to keep its settings separate. It does not contain an installer and does not include all the changes described here.

Start here

Photo Card Organizer brings photos and videos from cards and folders into libraries arranged the way you choose. It uses information such as capture date and camera model when available. Start with the setup steps below; warnings explain when an action can move or remove source files.



How files are protected

Copy leaves source files in place. A move between drives copies each file, checks its size and whether the source changed, and writes the required records before removing the source. Required backups must also succeed. On the same filesystem, reorganization can rename files without copying their contents. Existing files are not overwritten. Full checksum checks are separate, manual actions.

Guide map

Section	Use it for
Install and launch	Install the self-contained package and open the desktop or tray application.
Manage libraries	Choose where files belong and which library receives new imports by default.
Onboard a card	Identify a card, choose a camera label, configure sorting, and approve the first scan.
Organize a folder	Import an existing library or working folder without placing identity files in it.
Watch incoming folders	Save a folder as a Digest Inbox and keep track of new and completed imports.
Travel and export	Bring files home from another computer and make copies for editing.
Safety and recovery	Understand checksums, backups, conflicts, space limits, logs, and error handling.
Reference	Find folder tokens, command-line operations, and troubleshooting steps.

Before using Move

Run at least one copy session with the real camera, card reader, primary library, and backup drives. Open several imported JPEG, RAW, video, and sidecar files before enabling source deletion.

1. Install and launch

Windows

1**Run the installer**

Open **PhotoCardOrganizer-Installer-0.12.0.dev1.exe**. This is separate from PhotoCardOrganizer.exe, which launches the installed application. The single offline installer contains Python, PySide6, all application dependencies, and this guide.

2**Choose integration**

Desktop and Start Menu shortcuts are selected by default for a new installation; login monitoring is optional. Upgrades retain previous choices, so select Desktop shortcut to add one to an existing installation. Launch shortcuts use the application icon and taskbar identity. The Start Menu group includes the PDF guide and Uninstall shortcut. Pinning to the taskbar remains a Windows user action.

3**Install, repair, or remove**

The Ready page summarizes the operation before files are changed. When an installation is detected, the same Installer file offers repair/upgrade or uninstall.

4**Launch**

Start Photo Card Organizer from the wizard or selected shortcut. Only one application instance runs; a later launch restores the existing window.

```
PhotoCardOrganizer-Installer-0.12.0.dev1.exe
```

Linux

```
sudo apt install ./photo-card-organizer_0.12.0.dev1_amd64.deb
photo-card-organizer

chmod +x PhotoCardOrganizer-0.12.0.dev1-x86_64.AppImage
./PhotoCardOrganizer-0.12.0.dev1-x86_64.AppImage
```

The Debian package and AppImage contain the Python application runtime. The same executable also supports command-line operations. Tray availability depends on the desktop environment, particularly on Wayland.

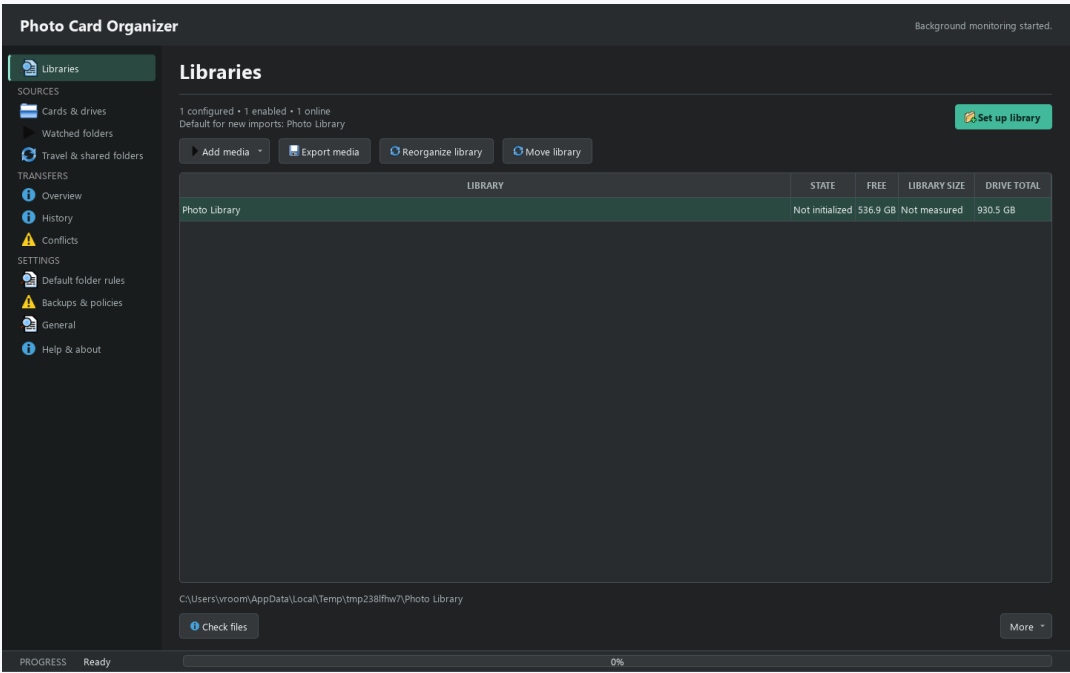
Optional ExifTool

When ExifTool is available on PATH, it expands RAW and video metadata support. Files still transfer without it; unavailable fields fall back to other metadata readers, file time, or the retained card profile.

Installation maintenance

Keep the downloaded Installer file as the single Windows maintenance entry point. Running it again detects the installed package and offers repair/upgrade or uninstall. Settings > General > Manage installation reports the detected installation and opens the registered uninstaller; Windows Installed apps and the Start Menu expose the same uninstall path. The uninstaller preserves per-user settings, profiles, and logs by default and never targets imported media or transfer records. Developer environments expose their local scripts.

2. Find your way around



Menu section	Page	Purpose
Libraries	Libraries / Add media	Choose your libraries, import a folder or combine collections.
Libraries	Export / Check files	Export selected media; manually check saved checksums, create records or compare a backup.
Sources	Cards & drives	Set up cards and drives, save their settings and see which are connected.
Sources	Watched folders / Travel	Incoming folders and laptop/shared-folder transfers using mounted destinations.
Transfers	Overview / History	Connected sources, current activity and error events.
Transfers	Conflicts	Search, compare preserved files side by side and update review status.
Settings	Default folder rules	Choose folder layouts, filename patterns and file types.
Settings	Backups & policies	Backup destinations, free-space limits and expandable advanced options.
Settings	General	Monitoring, card identity files, portable settings and installation maintenance.
Help	Help & about	PDF manual, changelog, diagnostics, version and project credits.

The sidebar is the only main navigation. Libraries provides Add media, Export media, Reorganize library and Move library. Check files acts on the selected library; More contains details, Open folder, defaults and maintenance. Import, export and checks have a Libraries back button. Progress stays visible. Save settings appears on settings pages or whenever changes are unsaved.

Sources and Transfers pages are direct sidebar choices. Cards and watched folders use compact toolbars with secondary actions under More. General includes advanced card identity filenames. Backups & policies keeps backups and free space visible; other options expand when needed. Collapsing sections preserves their values.

3. Onboard a card or drive

Choose Sources > Cards & drives > Add card > Connected card or drive. The setup wizard pauses monitoring while you choose settings, and asks for confirmation before writing identity files or scanning. Add card > Offline card profile saves a profile for later connection; it does not write to a disconnected card.

1

Card identity

Choose the card or drive root, display name, stable card ID, optional camera-name override, and media source folders such as DCIM. An existing identity is detected and loaded.

2

Destination

Choose a named primary library, optional Wedding, Client Shoot, Trip, or custom subfolder route, and transfer method. Copy is recommended for initial use.

3

Organization and safety

Choose a folder preset or retain detailed rules, enable media classes, set destination reserves, and optionally enable online place names. Checksums are a separate manual action.

4

Review

Read the concise source, destination, operation, media, camera, verification, organization, and backup summary. Nothing is written or scanned until the **Confirm initial scan and import** prompt is accepted.

Move receives another warning

After the initial review, Move displays a separate confirmation explaining source removal, required logs and backups before transfer work begins.

Identity layout

```
CARD_ROOT/  
|-- .photocard/  
|   |-- identity.json  
|   |-- transfers/  
|-- DCIM/
```

The identity folder is stored at the card root, not inside DCIM. Its folder name, identity filename, history folder, and transfer-record naming are configurable. The root marker lets multiple computers recognize the same card.

Saved card settings

The app remembers the card's name, location, camera override, source folders, destination subfolder and copy or move preference. You can edit these settings while the card is disconnected. Adding an offline profile saves settings on this computer; it does not write an identification file to an absent card.

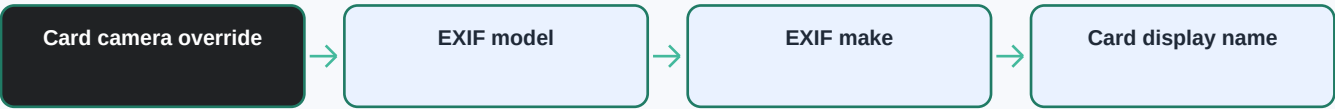
4. Camera metadata and folder organization

Named library destinations

Libraries retains multiple primary destinations and one default. Set up library creates or connects a destination; connecting an existing folder does not scan, import, or move media. A destination may be local, removable, or a network folder already mounted and authenticated by the operating system. Each library keeps versioned identity, migration state, manifests, and session records under its own .photocard-organizer folder. Initialize, check, upgrade, or repair metadata requires a separate confirmation and never changes media files.

The Libraries table shows free space, library size and total drive capacity. The selected library's folder appears below the table. Use **More > Refresh library size** to measure its file total in the background. The cached result includes metadata and conflicts, excludes links, and can differ from allocated disk space. Refresh after imports or reorganization when needed; the app does not repeatedly scan idle libraries.

Camera make and model are extracted automatically from EXIF when available. ExifTool is preferred when installed; Pillow and ExifRead provide additional fallbacks. The Camera folder token resolves in this order:



When to use the override

Leave Camera name override empty for normal EXIF behavior. Enter a value when a camera writes inconsistent model strings, metadata is absent, or several cards should share one controlled library label.

Camera folders reduce collisions, but do not guarantee uniqueness

Two bodies of the same model normally report the same EXIF camera label, and many cameras restart names such as IMG_0001. For a mixed library, keep the override blank, organize by date and camera, and use a filename such as {date:%Y%m%d_%H%M%S}_{original}. Any remaining different-content collision is preserved in the local conflict-review folder.

Folder presets

Preset	Result below the optional library subfolder
Date then camera	Media type / year / shoot date / camera
Camera then date	Media type / camera / year / shoot date
Date only	Media type / year / shoot date
Media folder only	Media type
None (no folders)	Filename directly below the library subfolder
Use current detailed rules	Keeps the independent Organization-page levels for each media class

Detailed folder tokens

Token	Example	Source
{date:%Y-%m-%d}	2026-07-12	Capture date, then file time fallback
{date:%m - %B}	07 - July	Standalone capture month
{date:%d}	12	Standalone capture day
{date:%G-W%V}	2026-W28	ISO Monday-start week; week-year can differ near New Year
{camera}	Canon EOS R5	Override or EXIF camera
{make} / {model}	Canon / EOS R5	EXIF make or model
{location}	Asheville, North Carolina	GPS and optional online place lookup
{rating}	4 stars	EXIF/XMP rating
{card}	R5 Card A	Retained card name
{media}	Raw	Detected media class
{capture_group}	Long Exposure Brackets	High-confidence conditional group; omitted otherwise
{original}	IMG_0421.CR3	Original filename

Conditional long-exposure folders

Capture grouping can detect nearby photo/RAW exposures that share a source folder and camera label, contain at least the configured number of captures, include a long exposure, and vary shutter duration or exposure bias. Add Long-exposure brackets as a media folder level to use the result. Non-qualifying files omit that level; same-stem sidecars inherit a qualifying capture's group.

5. Import or merge a library

Use **Import or merge** for media already stored in a normal folder, another managed library, a backup, or a removable transfer drive. This workflow never creates a .photocard identity or portable history inside the source.

1**Source**

Select the source folder and choose whether to include subfolders. Transfer details contains an optional label for the import's records. Choosing a folder does not begin a scan.

2**Destination**

Choose the receiving library, import grouping, Copy or Move, folder layout and media types. Event fields appear only for a named grouping. Expand Advanced options for a camera override, source-folder analysis or detailed rules.

3**Review**

Read the scan scope, destination, copy/move operation, organization and backup plan. Save settings + Import saves the reviewed settings after final confirmation. Move receives an additional source-removal warning.

Detected mappings follow the source scope

Changing the source path, recursive scan setting, or enabled media types clears a previously detected mapping. Analyze again or choose another folder layout so stale source assumptions are never reused silently.

Analysis preview versus full import

Structure analysis previews at most 10,000 filesystem files and offers up to twelve editable source-folder levels. If the preview limit is reached, the dialog says so and shows how many files informed the mapping. The eventual import is not capped and scans every enabled media file in the selected scope.

Why a separate destination is required

Import or merge needs a source folder outside the receiving library. To change a library's own layout, use Libraries > Reorganize library. A detailed preview is optional, but a final confirmation is always required.

Supported file classes

Photos, RAW files, videos and sidecars can each use a different layout. Sidecars are companion files, such as XMP files containing editing settings. Choose which file types to include, edit their extensions, and set up to twelve folder levels and a filename pattern in Organization. Use None to omit a level, or type a fixed folder name.

First backup-library test

Use an empty destination, Copy and recursive scanning for the first test. Keep Camera override empty to use each file's EXIF make/model. Exact-content and different-content destination conflicts are preserved locally for review. The app does not scan a library for identical content under unrelated filenames. Manual Check files can compare checksums afterward.

Merge and migrate libraries

Merge library

In Libraries, select the receiving library and choose **Add media > Combine another library**. Choose the source, save pending settings and review the proposed paths. Saved organization rules apply to incoming files; existing destination media keeps its layout. Content comparisons occur only on actual destination conflicts, not throughout the library.

Different filenames remain separate files. Both exact-content and different-content destination conflicts are preserved in the local Conflicts folder with the intended hierarchy. Source media stays in place for copy operations. Recorded source identity helps a repeated merge skip completed copies without hashing again.

Combine libraries asks for confirmation, copies to temporary files before completing each transfer, checks file sizes and source changes, and records completed work. It does not automatically create checksums. Use Check files afterward if you need them. Cancel stops further work; completed transfers remain recorded for a later retry.

Move a library to a new location

Select the library and choose **Move library**, then choose an empty destination. Close other clients using either location. The dialog shows Move library and Copy and keep originals as alternatives. Preview changes plans the paths; the final action asks for confirmation. Compatible same-filesystem moves rename the library; other transfers use staged copies and source-state checks. Existing checksum records are retained.

Moving a library does not normally read every file to calculate a checksum. Size checks catch incomplete copies, but not damage that leaves a file the same size. Use Check files when a full check is needed. If you resume an older job that requested checksum verification, that job keeps its original setting.

If a move is interrupted

Reconnect the original source and destination, then use Resume interrupted operation. Leave temporary files and recovery records in place. The app uses these records to continue safely; it keeps source files if required copies, backups or records fail, or if a destination changed unexpectedly. Installation and physical-drive tests remain incomplete for this preview.

Scope of this preview

Use Add media to bring files into a library, or select Reorganize library or Move library for those operations. Check files can detect changes using saved checksums. To restore a damaged file, you need a backup that matches its saved checksum. Network destinations must already be connected through your operating system; the app does not provide its own remote login service.

Reorganize an existing library

1**Choose the library**

In Libraries, select an available library and choose Reorganize library. Save any pending settings first. Monitoring pauses while the plan is prepared.

2**Choose the layout**

Separate by media type creates Photos, RAW, Videos, and Sidecars folders. Other presets add date or camera levels; Use current detailed rules keeps the saved folder definitions, including conditional bracket folders. Choose which media classes to include. Filenames are retained.

3**Preview changes (optional)**

Read current and proposed paths, including Already organized and potential Conflict review entries. Preview does not change media or save settings. You can select Reorganize directly to calculate the plan and continue to the final confirmation.

4**Review and reorganize**

Read the explicit move warning and summary before accepting. Save this layout for this library's future imports commits library-specific naming rules when processing starts. Other libraries and global rules remain unchanged. Remove folders left empty is optional.

Keep an independent backup

Within the same filesystem, files can be renamed without copying or rereading their contents. Moves between drives check the destination copy before removing the source. Required backups and records must succeed. Files changed since planning are left for later, and conflicting files go to the organized Conflicts folder without replacing existing files.

The app works from a fixed list so it does not import its own output. It excludes metadata, card identities and conflict folders. Saved checksum records follow the new paths, while old session logs are kept unchanged. A whole folder can be renamed at once when all its contents are supported media. If something fails, check Transfers > History and resume the operation; leave its recovery records in place.

Location rules use cached place names during preview; no online requests are made. Missing capture dates use file modification time. Use current detailed rules applies saved folder and filename templates, including library overrides; other presets retain original filenames.

Integrity checks

Open Libraries > Check files. Select Whole library or Selected files, then Check saved checksums. Select changed or missing results to Restore selected from backup. Recovery accepts only bytes matching the saved checksum and preserves damaged originals. A checksum detects damage; it cannot reconstruct a file without a good copy.

Recovery preserves damaged originals under `.photocard-organizer/integrity/recovery/OPERATION/original` and writes matching local and portable journals before replacement. After an interruption, the staged copy and original remain available; rerun verification and recovery with the backup connected. Never remove recovery folders until you have reviewed their contents.

Libraries > Edit selected > Organization settings offers per-media folder and filename overrides. Unchecked media inherit the global Organization settings. Saving settings does not move existing media; use Reorganize library and its final confirmation.

Settings > Backups & policies supports multiple destinations. Missing removable or network mounts are reported, not created. Required failures retain move sources. Backup conflicts keep the backup unchanged and preserve the incoming version locally. Marking reviewed does not finish a blocked transfer. Before retrying, the intended backup path must be empty or contain the accepted incoming version. Preserve the older version separately if replacing it. Unchanged unresolved conflicts do not create another review copy or repeat checksum reads.

Compare with backup uses a chosen configured destination and reports Matches backup, Different from backup, Missing from backup or Missing from library. It does not change media or choose an authoritative copy. Differences alone do not establish which version is damaged. Reports are saved locally and in the library.

Create missing checksums saves a reference checksum for files that do not already have one. It does not replace earlier records. A new checksum describes the file as it is now; it cannot tell you whether the file was damaged before this first check. Cancel stops the check and keeps completed results in the report.

Where checksums are saved

The library's checksum database is stored at `.photocard-organizer/integrity/catalog.sqlite3`. Older `integrity.sqlite3` databases are copied into this location when needed; the old file is kept as a fallback. Leave active database and recovery files uncompressed.

6. Watch incoming folders

Use **Sources > Watched folders** to save an incoming folder as a Digest Inbox. Its subfolders do not need to match your library's layout. It can be a local folder, removable drive, connected network share or locally synced cloud folder. Keep it outside the receiving library.

1**Add a folder**

Choose Add folder, a readable name and an incoming location. Enable subfolders for a varied legacy tree, then optionally select a receiving-library subfolder or camera override.

2**Choose Copy or Move**

Leave Copy selected for normal use. Automatic imports are copy-only and run at the interval you choose. Move requires a manual action and confirmation.

3**Review and import**

Select the folders and choose Import new files. Check the source, destination, copy or move choice, backups and folder rules before confirming. More contains edit, open and forget actions.

4**Check the results**

Filter by pending, processed, failed or conflict. The table shows recent entries and the total number recorded. The app remembers each file's progress and records each manual run separately.

Copy does not multiply unchanged files

Copy leaves the incoming source in place, but a later scan recognizes the same relative path, size, and modification time and reports it as already handled instead of creating another destination copy. A changed file is treated as new work.

Moving removes source files

Move requires review and a second warning. A source is removed only after its primary copy, completion/size/source-change checks, required backups and required transfer records succeed. Any failure retains the source for retry.

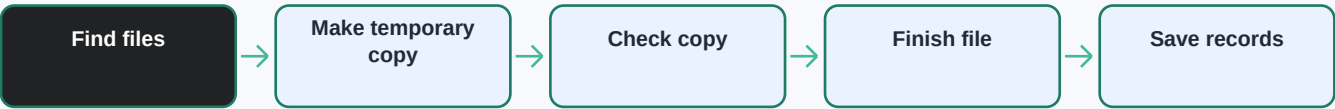
Cloud and shared folders

The app reads the local folder provided by your operating system or cloud-sync app. Automatic imports never delete source files. Be careful with Move in a synced folder: deleting a local file may also delete it online or on other devices. Use Copy unless you have backups and have tested that behavior.

Forgetting a profile removes only its saved connection. Incoming files, master-library files, and retained local digest history are unchanged.

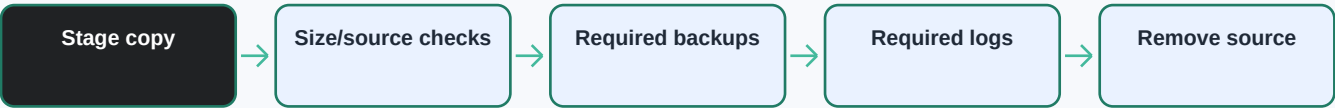
7. Copy or move files

Copy



Copy is the default globally and per card. Existing destination files are not overwritten. The source remains unchanged even if a backup, log, location lookup, or metadata field fails.

Move



When the source stays in place
The app does not remove the source if a required copy, backup or transfer record is incomplete. On retry, it can reuse a recorded copy if neither that copy nor its source has changed.

If the computer loses power during a temporary copy, the source remains. On the next write to that folder, the app removes abandoned partial files owned by the same client; it does not remove another client's in-progress partials.

What the checks can tell you

Setting	Choices	Notes
Ordinary transfers	Completion / size / source state	No automatic checksum read; same-size corruption is not detected.
Manual checks	Saved checksum / backup comparison	Run explicitly under Libraries > Check files.
New checksum records	Files without saved checksums	Describes the file now; cannot prove it was never damaged.

The footer progress bar reports files checked during scans and imports. Activity records meaningful events without inserting every progress tick.

8. Backups, clones, and free space

Under Settings > Backups & policies, choose Add destination in Backup destinations. Select a destination to enable Edit selected or Remove selected. Each can be enabled, required or optional and receive matching history. Conflicting backup files remain unchanged; the incoming version is preserved locally for review.

Destination type	Import behavior	Move behavior
Primary library	Always required	Must verify before deletion
Required backup	Failure leaves work pending for retry	Must verify before deletion
Optional clone	Failure is recorded as a warning	Does not block deletion after all required targets succeed

Space safeguards

The application checks both minimum free percentage and minimum free GB. It can block, try fallback destinations then block, or continue below the configured reserve when enough physical bytes remain.

A full drive never offers Continue

Manual space prompts can offer another destination, skip, or stop. Continue below reserve appears only when the drive has enough physical space for the file.

A low source free-space threshold is informational. It never silently changes Copy to Move.

9. Duplicates and filename conflicts

If an incoming file would use a name already present at its destination, the app compares the contents. Whether the files match or differ, the incoming file is kept in the local Conflicts folder for later review. The transfer does not stop for each filename conflict. Files with unrelated names are not searched for duplicates across the entire library.

Policy	Result
Different content	Always place the incoming file below the configured local conflict-review root while retaining the normal media/date/camera hierarchy.
Exact-content collision	Preserve the incoming copy below the same organized conflict-review root; never automatically delete it.
Repeated conflict name	Append _2, (2), or the configured {number} pattern to retain every version.

Conflict review

Preserved conflicts are queued in Conflict review. SQL-backed search and fixed 200-record pages keep very large histories bounded. Select one row for side-by-side paths, sizes, modification times, and supported image previews. Multi-select routine groups to mark their review status together; this status change never modifies either media file. RAW or video formats without a preview still show details and can be opened externally.

Filename conflicts do not interrupt

Both exact and different filename conflicts are preserved for later review. Low-space or file errors may still require action. Required backup conflicts retain move sources until resolved; marking a conflict reviewed does not delete or replace files.

10. Transfer records and multiple computers

Open Settings > Backups & policies and expand Transfer records to choose portable and local history, record folders and filename patterns. These options no longer sit beside the photo and video folder-rule tabs.

Each transfer session receives its own JSON Lines record and, when cryptographic verification is used, a separate checksum file. Session names can include date, card, computer, session, instance, library, card ID, and algorithm tokens. Library metadata and application-owned records use the canonical .photocard-organizer folder.

```
CARD_ROOT/.photocard/transfers/2026/2026-07/  
2026-07-12_14-30-05_R5-Card_Studio-PC_a1b2c3d4.jsonl  
2026-07-12_14-30-05_R5-Card_Studio-PC_a1b2c3d4.sha256
```

Matching local records

```
DESTINATION/.photocard-organizer/transfer-records/CARD_ID/
```

A small local database remembers imported files, unfinished transfers, watched-folder progress, conflicts and shared-folder transfers. It also caches place names to avoid repeating online lookups. It does not search the entire library for identical files with unrelated names.

Cross-computer use

The card identity and portable session records allow another configured computer to recognize the same card and determine which source items were already handled. Retained client profiles control local preferences while the stable card ID links the records.

Do not manually edit active session files

A malformed or unwritable required record blocks source deletion. Preserve identity and history folders when reformatting or retiring a card if the audit history is still needed.

Identity and session records remain uncompressed by default. They are generally tiny beside camera media, directly readable during recovery, and safer to synchronize between computers as separate completed files.

11. Travel libraries and shared folders

Sources > Travel & shared folders provides two copy-only ways to bring files home. Under Travel libraries, choose Add source for a directly reachable laptop share or removable library, select it, then choose Copy new files and review the confirmation. More contains edit, open-folder and forget actions. Expand Shared transfer folders for USB, SMB/NAS or locally synchronized cloud-folder transport. Saved shared-folder profiles make that section open by default.

Method	Best use	Behavior
Retained travel source	A laptop share, attached travel drive, or USB library	Scan that source directly and retain its stable profile so later runs import only new work.
Shared transfer folder	USB drive, SMB/NAS share, or locally synced cloud folder	One computer publishes files; another catches new sessions and records which ones it imported.

USB drive workflow

- 1

Configure the laptop
Expand Shared transfer folders and choose Add shared folder on the USB drive with role Publish and a unique channel name, such as Field-Laptop. Card imports can copy to it as a backup destination. Use Publish now to send files imported while the drive was disconnected.
- 2

Wait for completion
Confirm the publish progress and session record finish before using the operating system's safe-eject command. Source and laptop-library files are never deleted by hub publication.
- 3

Configure the desktop
Attach the USB drive, add the same hub folder with role Catch, and select Catch new sessions. The desktop applies its own organization rules to the incoming producer channel.
- 4

Check that files arrived
After the desktop records the import, it saves a completion record locally and in the shared folder. Catching the same unchanged session again should import no new files.

Paths can change
If Windows assigns a different USB drive letter, or Linux mounts the drive at a different path, edit the saved hub folder before running it. The producer channel and recorded sessions remain unchanged.

Network and cloud folders

For SMB/NAS, authentication and reconnect behavior are handled by the operating system. For Google Drive or another cloud service, choose a normal locally synchronized folder and make its files available offline. Version 0.12.0.dev1 does not request cloud API credentials, and reported local free space may not reflect remote quota.

Use one role per client for a given hub and a distinct producer channel for every publishing laptop or tablet. This prevents circular publication and keeps receipts attributable.

12. Export captures for editing

Choose a library in **Libraries**, then **Export media**. This does not change the default import destination. Scanning reads metadata without changing source files. Matching stems and corresponding organized paths become capture sets; Photos, RAW, and Sidecars partitions are normalized during matching.

1**Scan the selected library**

Choose a saved library and select Scan library. Internal manifest and transfer-record folders are excluded. Changing libraries clears the old selection.

2**Filter media and dates**

Choose All media, Photos, RAW, Videos, or Sidecars. Enable Capture date range for inclusive start/end dates; missing capture metadata falls back to file modification time. Include matching sidecars is optional. For example, select Videos and the required dates, then Select all matching.

3**Review detected sets**

Expand Capture grouping to adjust bracket/burst and interval thresholds, complete-group selection and group folders. This section scrolls in smaller windows. Review camera, capture time, rating, media types and group labels.

4**Select work**

Select one or more captures, Select all matching, or expand a detected group. Group expansion stays inside the active media/date filters. Optional group subfolders keep bracketed and interval sequences together.

5**Export**

Choose a separate editing folder and review the confirmation, group folders, conflict suffix and space reserve. Export is copy-only with size/source-change checks. Actual filename conflicts are compared; matching exports may be reused and different versions receive a suffix. Records are written under .photocard-organizer/export-sessions.

Grouping is a review aid

Bracket and interval detection is based on timestamps, folder, and compatible camera labels. Review the selected rows before export; the app does not infer creative intent or alter the master library.

The editing folder cannot be inside the master library or contain it. The configured destination free-percent and free-GB reserves also apply to editing exports. If a source changes while it is being copied, the issue is recorded and no partial destination is committed.

13. Tray, monitoring, and settings portability

Closing the window hides the application when tray support is available. The tray menu can restore the window, scan now, pause or resume monitoring, and quit. Copy cards and enabled copy-only Digest Inboxes can be handled automatically; Move sources wait for an explicit manual confirmation.

New settings check connections every 30 seconds. Unchanged card file scans gradually back off to the Maximum idle-card scan interval, initially 300 seconds, to reduce disk activity. Scan now forces discovery and scanning immediately. New mount changes trigger discovery without forcing unchanged connected cards to rescan. A card replaced at the same drive letter between checks, or changes on a still-mounted source, may wait until the next idle scan. Saved intervals are retained; Digest Inbox and hub intervals remain separate.

Portable client settings

Export settings creates a JSON file containing organization, named-library definitions, safety, media, card-profile, backup, travel/hub, Digest Inbox, and history definitions. Machine-specific library, card, backup, travel, hub, digest, fallback, and local-log paths are removed. Named libraries, travel sources, hubs, and Digest Inboxes arrive without another computer's local path; importing over the same stable ID retains that client's existing path and enabled state.

1**Export**

Open General options > Export settings and store the JSON file securely.

2**Install on the other computer**

Complete installation and choose local destination and log paths.

3**Import**

Use Import settings, review the merge confirmation, and then map retained card or backup roots as needed.

Online place names

Online GPS-to-place lookup is off by default. When enabled, coordinates are sent to the configured provider. Nominatim requests are rate-limited and cached locally. Lookup failure never blocks transfer; the folder rule falls back to coordinates or Unknown location.

14. Troubleshooting

Symptom	What to check
Windows shows an unknown publisher	The private release is currently unsigned. Verify the installer filename and SHA-256 checksum before choosing Run anyway.
Application Control blocks the installer	Do not disable protection or add an exception just to test this preview. Installation testing remains incomplete; use a compatible isolated test environment or wait for a validated package.
Installer reports the app is running	Close the main window and quit from the tray icon, then continue. The installer uses the application mutex to prevent files from changing underneath a running transfer.
Application opens instead of installer	PhotoCardOrganizer.exe is the installed application launcher. Run the separately downloaded PhotoCardOrganizer-Installer-version.exe for install, repair, upgrade, or maintenance uninstall.
Structure preview reaches its limit	The 10,000-file limit applies only to organization analysis. Review the proposed mapping; the confirmed import still scans the complete selected source scope.
Installation verification failed	Run the same Installer file again to repair the package. Existing settings and card profiles are stored separately and remain in place.
Card is not detected	Confirm the card root contains the configured identity folder and identity filename; refresh cards; check the retained root; reconnect the reader.
No files were imported	Check enabled media classes and extensions, source folders, recursion, settle time, transfer history, and Activity messages.
Move kept the source	Check History for a failed copy, required backup, transfer record, space limit or permission error. The source stays in place until the required work succeeds. Older jobs may also require a checksum check.
Destination is unavailable	Reconnect the drive, choose an alternate destination during a manual import, or configure fallback roots.
USB hub is offline	Reconnect it and confirm the saved hub folder. If the drive letter or mount point changed, edit the profile before Publish or Catch.
Hub catch repeats files	Confirm both clients use stable producer/consumer identities and do not delete the hub session records or local manifest. Review receipt status.
Digest Inbox repeats a file	Confirm the profile ID and local manifest were retained and the source path, size, or modification time did not change. A changed source is intentionally new work.
Digest move kept the source	Check the file's failed state and History for copy, backup, record, source-change or free-space errors. The app keeps the source when a required step fails.
A conflict was preserved	Open Conflict review. Search by filename, compare both files, and use their external-open actions. Multi-select only records you have actually reviewed.
The in-app manual is unavailable	Repair the installed package or rebuild the release so the PDF version matches the application version exactly.
Tray icon is absent on Linux	Verify StatusNotifierItem/AppIndicator support. GNOME may need an AppIndicator extension. The window remains usable without tray support.
Scrolling appears inactive	Place the pointer over the form area. Lists, tables, and text regions intentionally handle their own wheel events.

Symptom	What to check
An import action asks to save first	Save settings is highlighted because visible controls differ from the saved configuration. Save before normal processing, or use the reviewed Import or merge action and its Save settings + Import button.

Safe response to an unfamiliar error

Choose Skip or Stop rather than forcing continuation. Source media is retained when transfer integrity is uncertain. Review Activity and the session records before retrying.

15. Command reference

```
python app.py                Open the desktop application
python app.py --service      Start hidden in the tray
python app.py --scan-once --dry-run  Preview connected-card work
python app.py --scan-once    Import copy cards once
python app.py --scan-once --confirm-move
python app.py --import-folder D:\Incoming --import-name "Travel"
python app.py --import-folder /mnt/incoming --no-subfolders
python app.py --digest-inbox legacy-drop
python app.py --digest-all
python app.py --digest-inbox disposable-move --confirm-move
python app.py --export-settings client-settings.json
python app.py --import-settings client-settings.json
python app.py --install-autostart
python app.py --init-config
python app.py --version
```

For a Debian installation, replace **python app.py** with **photo-card-organizer**. For an Appliance, use its path. All command-line arguments are forwarded to the bundled executable.

Create a card identity from the command line

```
python app.py --create-identity E:\ --card-name "Canon R5 Card A" --card-id canon-r5-a
```

Use **--digest-inbox PROFILE_ID** more than once to run selected saved profiles, or **--digest-all** for every enabled profile. Move operations from the command line require the explicit **--confirm-move** flag. Without it, destructive work remains blocked.

Validate the release

```
python -m unittest discover -s tests -v
```

Automated tests cover imports, organization rules, backup handling, conflicts, recovery records, interrupted jobs, settings upgrades and key interface workflows. Passing these tests does not replace testing the installed app with your own drives. See the validation record for checks that are still outstanding.

Release history

The complete cumulative CHANGELOG.md is included with every packaged release and opens from Help & about.

Version	Released	Highlights
0.12.0.dev1	Navigation preview	One sidebar, compact source actions, explicit move/copy choices and contextual settings controls. Source only.
0.11.3.dev4	Interface preview	Direct Settings navigation, grouped backups and general options, one travel page. Not packaged or installed.
0.11.3.dev3	Interface preview	Direct library actions, fewer tabs, simpler import options and compact reorganization. Not packaged or installed.
0.11.3.dev2	Testing preview	Simpler navigation, manual file checks and fewer repeated reads. Local installer built; installation testing is blocked. Native crashes are not confirmed fixed.
0.11.2	2026-09-16	On-demand library sizes, drive capacity visibility, and optional SHA-256 migration verification.
0.11.1	2026-09-13	Atomic catalog startup, immediate first monitoring scans, and Linux CI corrections.
0.11.0	2026-09-13	Verified backup recovery, library-specific naming rules, removable backup safeguards, Integrity action fixes, and schema-6 settings migration.
0.10.2	2026-09-13	Graphite, jade, and coral visual theme, refreshed application mark, and packaged SVG brand asset.
0.10.1	2026-09-13	Estimated transfer time remaining with average read/write rates and focused progress telemetry tests.
0.10.0	2026-09-08	Integrity checks, resumable same-filesystem reorganization, lower-I/O verification, and expanded folder levels.
0.9.0	2026-09-07	Content-based library merge, verified location migration, portable integrity baselines, and dialog lifecycle fixes.
0.8.0	2026-09-06	In-place library reorganization, filtered named-library exports, and reduced scanning overhead.
0.7.2	2026-09-06	Fixed Windows Qt packaging and added full installed-GUI verification.
0.7.1	2026-07-31	Simplified Libraries and Import or merge workflows, clearer metadata actions, destination carry-over, and focused progressive disclosure.
0.7.0	2026-07-28	Named libraries, schema-5 and library metadata migration, named import routes, Month and conditional long-exposure folders, saved-settings enforcement, and persistent progress.
0.6.1	2026-07-27	Large/deep library analysis clarity, twelve editable levels, bounded-result transparency, and clearly named Windows maintenance.
0.6.0	2026-07-27	Guided existing-library import, explicit structure analysis, focused Travel tabs, in-app changelog, and clearer disabled actions.
0.5.0	2026-07-26	Digest Inboxes, scalable conflict review, Help/manual/changelog access, and high-resolution taskbar/tray icons.
0.4.0	2026-07-26	Travel libraries, shared USB/SMB/cloud-folder hubs, digestion receipts, grouped editing exports, and consolidated maintenance.
0.3.0	2026-07-18	Upgradeable Windows installer, repair/uninstall flow, Linux packages and CLI, schema migration, and versioned PDF packaging.
0.2.0	2026-07-15	PySide6 desktop/tray UI, multi-card queue, existing-library import, profiles, replicas, conflicts, and workflow polish.
0.1.0	2026-07-15	First working camera-card import release preserved as a separate snapshot.

Quick operating checklist

Before import	After import
Destination and required backups are connected	Progress completed and Activity has no unresolved error
Correct card or folder source is selected	Representative JPEG, RAW, video, and sidecar files open
Copy is selected for a new workflow	Folder names match date, camera, location, and rating expectations
Enabled extensions match the camera	Required backup copies and transfer records exist
Digest Inbox is separate and Copy is selected	Per-file queue is processed and a repeat imports nothing
USB/network hub path and role are correct	Publish/catch receipts exist and a repeated catch imports nothing
Free-space reserves leave adequate headroom	Only then consider enabling Move for later sessions

Recommended first session

Onboard one card, leave Copy selected, use Date then camera, enable only the media classes the camera writes, and import a small test shoot. Inspect primary and backup results before unattended use.

Release: Photo Card Organizer 0.12.0.dev1

This guide applies to Photo Card Organizer 0.12.0.dev1. Configuration and transfer-record files are plain JSON or JSON Lines; the local manifest is SQLite. Imported media is never intentionally overwritten.

Programmers / designers

The Meat Popsicle - product direction, design judgment, field testing, and possession of the cameras.
Codex, Latest Robot Overlord - programming, systems design, documentation, and strictly limited authority over folder names.